Fierce Fairytales

(Societal Impacts on Men)

By Nakita Gill

Man Up, Hercules (Pg 127-128)

When I was a child,
my worst nightmare was to see my father cry.

It occurs to me now that the world around me
doesn't want men to feel.
It emphasizes stoicism till they bottle up their feelings.

And if ever one of them falters, 'man up'
becomes the dark magic to charm them back into line.
'Man up' is that villain who shows up with lackeys
'grow a pair' and 'boys don't cry'.

We tell our sons stories about heroes like Hercules,
but forget to mention how Hercules' rage
caused him to murder his entire family.

And by telling them stories where anger becomes
the only acceptable way they can express themselves, we
are teaching them shouting, punching, yelling
is all they can ever do to release themselves from hell.

And this is how cursed phrases
like 'man up' contribute

4NG Fanatics

to the greatest killer of men under 45.

Repression leads to depression,
depression leads to trying to find ways to be alive
and after years of being told not to feel,
the only way to truly feel it all becomes suicide.

We have created nooses with words
and watch passively as our sons tighten them
around each other's necks.

So I will tell my son, I will say, **Cry,**
let the dam burst, and let the rivers you are holding back run free.
It will release everything that hurts you
and finally you will be able to breathe.

The definition of who you are as a man is too powerful
to be swayed by a phrase,
it doesn't have to be proven through self-hate.

When they tell you to 'man up'
look them in the eyes and just say, 'I will not, no.'

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

INTRODUCTION

Men in our society today are suffering, and the people in their immediate circles are in crisis because of it. Men can literally be self-destructing right before our eyes and we just ignore it. See, society hasn't done a good job equipping men for the roles we expect them to step into. We expect good men, wise men, protectors; but we don't equip them to be the men we want and need them to be. The bottom line is that hurt people hurt people . . . By the time most men figure out they are damaged, it's usually too late.

Nakita Gill examines this societal travesty in her book of poems entitled: Fierce Fairytales

Child's Play (Pg 25)

It always begins when we are children
with imaginations so big we put
whole universes to shame.

We tell each other stories
layered with childlike epiphany
and fiery self-belief

We squabble over who
gets to play the princess
or the hero prince.

None of us want to be
the dragon that is slayed

4NG Fanatics

nor the ogre nor the witch.
Right there in our child's mind
we decide everyone can
only be very evil or very good.

We never stop to consider
that all of us are capable
of doing terrible things.

We have all taken turns
being Red Riding Hood
and we have all been the wolf

TRANSITION

But as is true for everyone, we grew up . . . our world changed and the fairy tales darkened

How a Hero Becomes a Villain (Pg 51-52)

Trauma when left untreated
has the capacity to make
a villain out of you.

No one understands how little boys
who save villages, who become war heroes,
who have fathers that just expect
them to be brave no matter the cost
become villains without even trying to.

How you weren't always an arrogant,
self-involved, obsessive bad guy, how that is

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

just the way you project yourself
to keep the vulnerable little boy hidden;
this is what is expected of you,
the strongest man in the whole village.

This is how a hero like Gaston
becomes the devil in the story which could
Have been about his only chance at finding love.

Take this as your reminder.
Not all heroes wear capes.
Some wear darkness, some wear wounds.

The Woods Reincarnated (Pg 13)

[And as time passed]

We traded the woods for high-rises,

the wolf became the boy next door,

soft brown eyes and close-lipped smiles

to hide the flash of fangs instead of teeth.

The huntsman became the 'nice' man

that happened to live down the street

whose laugh never quite reached his eyes,

and the beaten track gets hazy

between grandmother and beast.

When the forest paths

4NG Fanatics

become the backstreets of a city,

Where predators learn a sweeter language

Accented with false niceties.

Sometimes it's the wolf that thrives.

[This is] What happens to the fairytale

when the woods have been replaced by cities;

and a concrete jungle that comes to life . . .

The Trolls (After Shane Koyczan) (Pg 105-108)

Banished beneath bridges,
there were once brewing beasts
we gave a different name.
We called them trolls before
but it appears their numbers
have doubled, have tripled
have quadrupled since.
So here it is,
an origin story about the monsters amongst us
with no princess or prince.
In desperation to save themselves
from the dreadful damp below bridges,
they began to prey on humanity.
But the more they tried to hurt us
the more we fought back
until one day we finally
managed to beat them back,

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

the stories became legend
and the legends became myths,
yet this is where the story really begins.

You see, the trolls were never dead.
They were simply asleep,
biding their time,
waiting for us to forget them,
to leave them as fairy stories.
When the first child turned on
his first computer, a tremor was felt.
And that was when they rose
from their man-made prison hell,
they wore new avatars
and had learned to embrace
their lack of empathy and morality,
instead of hearts they now devoured
hopes, dreams, and an entire human just being.

They seek out the depressed
and find the lonely,
they make targets out of children
and sow divisive seeds
amongst friends and families.
All through the words on a screen
they make weapons; sticks and stones,
shovels to bury dreams.

They break open souls,

4NG Fanatics

eat whatever happiness is left inside
and cause death and suicides,
destroy families and cause loss
using just words,
lies twisted into more lies.

We cannot hide from them,
cannot beat them back,
we cannot turn them into stories again,
we must face simple facts:
they now live amongst us
their bridges are burned and gone.
They wear armor made of code.

We cannot protect our children
from these evil beings,
but we can teach them
how to protect themselves.

TRANSITION

Unfortunately, protecting himself was never something that the Hatter in Alice in Wonderland learned to do. And while children love his fantastical character and the randomness of his thoughts, his existence too has a dark side. How did society impact the Hatter? Did it truly make him 'mad'? . . . hurt people hurt people.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

The Hatter

To understand what they did to the Hatter, I must first tell you about people who know how to play with your brokenness like it is a fidget spinner without so much as touching your skin-a form of abuse known as gaslighting.

You say it happened, they say it did not.
You say it had to, they say it cannot.

They pull at a thread of pain left by someone in your mind, and sew an entire ghost out of you.

Build you a dark wonderland and ask you to call it home. Tell you, 'Why can't you just be happy?' And you cannot because happiness in this story is a queen you do not trust being built from your own delusions.

When this happens, you are like the Hatter. Trapped here in this fairytale world, half mad because someone you love keeps lying to you.

Is this rain, dear? ***No it isn't, it's a raven.***
Is this a door? ***No, it is a writing desk.***

4NG fanatics

Is this my mind? ***No, it is now my rabbit hole, and I'm going to make you fall so far down there is no way out.***

This is why the raven becomes like a writing desk, nonsensical riddles and memories become valid, nothing makes sense anymore anyway.

You start wondering if anything you ever thought happened to you actually happened to you and this is their violence. This is their abuse. It has left bruises and gashes along your brain that no one else knows are there.

Doubting yourself is now a reflex. Trusting yourself is no longer muscle memory but a long, strenuous process.

They called the Hatter
completely mad.
Because he is cursed
to both remember
and to forget.

They call me mad too
because my curse is to heal
through remembering
everything you tried
to make me forget.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG Fanatics

****

'Man up'

'grow a pair'

'boys don't cry'

'Man up'

(Stand up straight and tall, square your shoulders and say with conviction)

'I will not, no.'

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Nakita Gill
Book: Fierce Fairytales
ISBN: 978-0316420747
Publisher: Hachette Books
Date (Month/Year): Sept 2018

AWARD HISTORY

2019 National Qualifier – MS
2023 National Qualifier – MS
KS State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY